

THE GOLD STANDARD

ICICI Bank, a five-time winner in the *BT-KPMG Best Banks and NBFCs Survey*, continues to raise the bar under MD & CEO Sandeep Bakhshi

BY ANAND ADHIKARI

A **ICICI BANK** turns 70, its journey, from a development finance institution to a bank, mirrors several defining leadership phases most prominently under N. Vaghul, who nurtured the institution; K. V. Kamath, who transformed it into a retail and technology giant; and now Sandeep Bakhshi, who restored its trust and durability.

Bakhshi didn't inherit a growth story but a trust deficit when the then MD & CEO, Chanda Kochhar, quit in 2018 amid charges of misconduct. One of his first decisions was ensuring the bank was process-led and not personality-led. He also initiated a balance sheet repair in what was one of the fastest clean-ups among large private banks; he reduced risky corporate exposure, scaled down international banking, and tightened underwriting discipline. He also initiated a culture reset by stressing growth with profitability.

These efforts have translated

into the bank being the Bank of the Year jury award winner for the fifth time in a row. This year, it has won the Best Large Indian Bank award in the *BT-KPMG Survey of India's Best Banks and NBFCs*. Under Bakhshi's leadership, ICICI Bank has evolved into a low-profile organisation with emphasis on systems and institutional strength rather than individuals. There are no big promises, no dramatic narratives, just predictable execution. Proof of this lies in Bakhshi's addresses in annual reports and investor calls, where he consistently emphasises the bank's strategic focus on growing profit before tax, excluding treasury, through a 360-degree customer-centric approach and tapping opportunities across eco-systems and micro-markets.

"We continue to operate within the framework of our values to strengthen our franchise. Maintaining high standards of governance, deepening coverage, and enhancing delivery capabilities with a focus on simplicity and

CHALLENGES AHEAD

With Bakhshi's tenure extended till 2028, leadership succession beyond his term remains a key overhang

CASA at 38-40% reflects the challenge of sustaining low-cost deposits amid intense competition

RBI-mandated provisioning on agricultural loans highlights regulatory compliance risk despite stable asset quality

Expanding AI use improves efficiency but raises governance, cyber, and regulatory execution risks

Stock underperformance in 2025 continues to weigh on investor sentiment despite strong fundamentals

| 39

